human rights. The EU has also evolved from a coal- and steel-trading bloc into one of the most integrated political and economic unions in the world.

These expansions were fueled by the increasing complexity of global challenges, from financial crises and pandemics to climate change and technological disruption. IOs responded by hiring elite specialists, investing in cutting-edge technologies like AI and satellite surveillance, and broadening their missions to tackle emerging global issues. This growth has come with enhanced authority, enabling IOs to influence domestic policies and shape international norms more dramatically than ever before.

The end of the Cold War marked an inflection point for IOs, catalyzing a rapid proliferation of institutions and a corresponding expansion of their roles (Johnson 2014; Morse and Keohane 2014; Pratt 2021). With the dissolution of the USSR, member states and IO bureaucrats seized the opportunity to address gaps in global governance. New organizations emerged, and existing ones reinterpreted their mandates to address previously neglected issues like gender equality, climate change, and cybersecurity (Jupille, Mattli, and Snidal 2013).

This explosion of IOs, while addressing many global challenges, also enabled states to shop among overlapping institutions to secure the most favorable terms (Busch 2007; Clark 2022). While this institutional diversity has enabled flexibility and innovation (Pratt 2018; Henning and Pratt 2020; Eilstrup-Sangiovanni 2021), it has also sparked redundancies and inefficiencies. For example, the development sector is now governed by twenty-eight multilateral organizations alongside a web of bilateral and informal arrangements. Similarly, the emergency lending regime, once dominated by the IMF, now includes eight regional financing arrangements. Figure 3.1 illustrates the dramatic increase in the number of IOs operating on the global stage over time.